

THE
VOLUME OF THE WORLD:

EMBRACING THE
GEOGRAPHY, HISTORY, AND STATISTICS,

OF THE
NATIONS OF THE EARTH:

THEIR
GOVERNMENTS, INSTITUTIONS, FINANCES, POPULATION, INDUSTRY, PRODUCTIONS, ARTS, SCIENCES, EDUCATION, RELIGION, LAWS, AND CUSTOMS;

WITH
COMPLETE STATISTICAL TABLES,

FROM THE LATEST AUTHENTIC SOURCES,

AND

ONE HUNDRED ILLUSTRATIONS

OF

WORKS OF ART AND NATURE, VIEWS OF CITIES, PUBLIC BUILDINGS, IMPORTANT LOCALITIES,
PROMINENT OBJECTS IN NATURAL HISTORY, AND DELINEATIONS
OF CIVILIZED AND SAVAGE LIFE;

ALSO EMBELLISHED WITH

A MAP OF THE WORLD, ON MERCATOR'S PROJECTION,

WITH

Its details brought down to the latest date of Geographical Discovery, and delineating
the Principal Voyages of Discovery since the time of Columbus.

BY THOMAS H. PRESCOTT, A. M.

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## PREFACE.

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THE design of this work is to afford the reader, in a condensed form, a statistical and descriptive view of the several nations of the earth,—to describe their governments, institutions, population, commerce, agriculture, manufactures, arts, sciences, education, religion, laws, manners and customs, and to briefly notice the prominent events of their history. Knowledge of this kind has become a necessary qualification for the pursuits of commerce and industry, and much of the ordinary and current business of life. The details have been brought down to as late a date as possible, in order to exhibit as nearly as can be accomplished, a contemporaneous view of the nations at the close of the first half of the nineteenth century. In a work involving such an infinite variety of details, some errors and imperfections will unavoidably occur. Balbi observes, with reference to works of this description, that they are necessarily a compound of things which are, with things which have ceased to be. “How,” he asks, “can one be informed of all the changes that take place in the course of a few years in the capitals of Europe, still more in those of Asia, Africa and America? To compose a work which should exhibit a complete picture of the globe at a particular period, it would be necessary to have authentic documents, all of the same date, and that a recent one; which never has been, and never can be.” All the merit the compiler of this volume can claim, is that of being laborious, and of endeavoring to be faithful. In the prosecution of his task he has made great exertions to avail himself of recent and reliable sources of information, and has had at his disposal a large and valuable library.

An attempt to give credit in the pages to the various works to which he is indebted, would have uselessly encumbered the book with notes and references of very little consequence to the general reader. A book of this kind must necessarily be a compilation,—and the compiler has availed himself of the labors of his predecessors, so far as they could be made useful to his purpose. “As well might a traveler presume to claim the fee-simple of all the country which he has surveyed, as a historian or geographer expect to preclude those who come after him from making a proper use of his labors. If the former writers have seen accurately and related faithfully, the latter ought to have the privilege of declaring the same facts.” Those who have preceded him have availed themselves of the observations of their predecessors, and this work in its turn may save some future compiler a portion of his toil. Every nation of the earth, civilized or savage; every rock of the ocean large enough for a sea gull to rest upon, has been made the subject of a volume; and as such works become multiplied, detailed and diffuse, it becomes a useful labor to abridge, and present in synoptical views all that is really valuable of their contents. In this way the compiler has endeavored to irrigate his pages, not only with rills and rivulets from those great reservoirs of geographical and statistical knowledge, the works of Balbi, Hassel, Malte Brun, McCulloch, Murray and his talented collaborators of the *Encyclopædia of Geography*, but he has also drawn freely from the fountains of scientific observation contained in the journals of enlightened travelers and voyagers to distant regions. His statistics of civilized nations are derived from authentic documents.

The engravings in the volume are not introduced for any purpose of mere embellishment; and it was for some time a question, whether the plan of a work of this kind would admit of their introduction;—but as they are now very generally used in descriptive works, both in this country and England, we have inserted such as will be found of more utility in conveying a clearer idea of the objects than can be accomplished by elaborate description. The drawings are believed to



be generally correct, and to many readers they will be acceptable, although some of them may present familiar views, which have been delineated repeatedly by the demand for embellished works. They may at least serve to call the attention of the young to the contents of the work, by arresting their curiosity,—an incentive that often proves the source of valuable attainments.

Believing the kind of information contained in this work to be of importance to all classes of society,—that none are so exalted as to rise above, and none so humble as to sink below, the common want of a knowledge of the world they live in,—and believing, also, that but few of our busy population have the leisure to search through a multitude of volumes to obtain the information condensed in this, the compiler respectfully tenders the result of his labors, in the hope that it may afford to the young a useful auxiliary in the pursuit of knowledge,—to the old, a work of authentic reference,—and to all a better knowledge of the World's vast Volume.





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